

Summary: Key & Exciting Events

Concise version based on the letter dated May 1, 1890, in Chicago

Ticket Purchases and Equipment in Gothenburg

The author and his companion Arvid purchased third-class tickets to New York via the Cunard Line for 80 kronor, deliberately choosing to face the journey's hardships head-on. They bought mattresses and mess kits, but faced early logistical trouble as some utensils vanished before departure.

Mattress Chaos and Lost Belongs

The purchased mattresses proved to be more trouble than they were worth, ruining clothes and ultimately being stolen or lost along with the tin mess kits during the chaotic transfer to the Atlantic liner S/S Aurania. This forced them to borrow utensils or eat off paper during the voyage.

The Dramatic Atlantic Crossing

The voyage took nine days due to severe weather. A violent storm struck the ship, causing widespread seasickness among the 1,100 passengers and crew. Miraculously, the author and Arvid remained entirely unaffected. The journey was also marked by freezing temperatures, encounters with icebergs near the Newfoundland Banks, and a day-long dense fog.

Arrival in New York and Castle Garden

Before anchoring, a spectacular thunderstorm broke out in the thick fog. Following a health inspection (smallpox screening/vaccination), they faced immense linguistic and logistical chaos at the Castle Garden emigrant station. They stayed at a cheap German hotel run by a Swedish-born owner who helped them secure highly advantageous train tickets westward.

Train Journey to Chicago and a Tragi-Comic Transfer

They traveled by express train via Canada, passing the Niagara River. During a sudden, last-second train transfer in Port Huron, they had to rush frantically to another train in the midday heat, dressed in winter overcoats and carrying arms full of loose belongings like slippers and beer bottles. As compensation, they were upgraded to first class for the remainder of the trip to Chicago.

Future Plans in the Swedish Hub of Chicago

The author was struck by the strange, scorched appearance of the American countryside and the general lack of cleanliness in country towns. Arriving in Chicago, they found it much more pleasant than New York. Since their train tickets to Los Angeles are valid for a full year, they are now considering staying in Chicago for some time to find work and learn the language before continuing to California.